

Maybe I Should Freelance?

The A-Z of Building a Sustainable
Freelance Writing Career

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Introduction

Hi, we're Aparajita and Soumya...

And this is a playbook of *everything* we know about building and sustaining careers as freelance writers. But before we get into what this playbook will tell you, we want to talk about why we are writing this. And to do that, we must quickly travel back a decade.

The year is 2015 and both of us meet at a journalism college in Bangalore. One of us leaves halfway through the course and enters a job market filled with bizarre and brilliant opportunities. The other completes the course, gets placed, and then realises that her truest talents exist beyond the boundaries of traditional journalism.

Some half a dozen turns later, this is where we find ourselves — Aparajita works across brand strategy, social media, content and consulting. Soumya teaches writing, strategizes content for startups, and edits. We both write.

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While the roles we have may sound common in today's workplaces, they weren't as clearly defined when we were starting out. So we each had to build our career on a series of experiments and leaps of faith.

And now, at a time when the market is once again changing, with AI and personal branding and portfolio careers in the picture, our hope in writing this playbook has been twofold.

First, we want to give you answers about freelancing and content writing that took us time to understand, and we want them to be easily accessible in one place.

Second, we want to share a map that enables you to think about your own journey long-term. Which is why through the course of this playbook, we offer our learnings, our mistakes, examples of work we admire, wisdom from fellow creative professionals, external resources that go beyond the scope we've promised, prompts to think deeper, and always, some much-needed cheerleading.

We created this playbook to help you get a head start in your career, avoid early mistakes that can be costly, find direction and perspective at a time when the market feels shaky, and okay, if we're being honest, to chart our own ways forward.

All of which is to say, this is a conversation. We are starting it, hoping you chime in, tell your own stories, and strengthen this ecosystem with us.

Here's to building worlds with words, separately and together.

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Aparajita & Soumya

Who Should read this and how

This playbook is a guide we wish we had at the start of our careers.

It will speak to you if:

- You want to begin or are in the first few years of your writing career.
- You have a few years under your belt and are wondering if you should switch to freelancing.
- You have tried freelancing but it felt chaotic and overwhelming. You wonder how others make it work.
- You feel isolated as a freelancer, and have no one to discuss your doubts with or bounce your ideas off of.
- You need resonance, someone who gets it to cheer you through the ups and downs of the freelance writer life.

The playbook is divided into three sections. In the first, The Business of Freelancing, you will find all the basics you'd otherwise go hunting for on Reddit or ChatGPT. We discuss how to set up your portfolio, identify the right and wrong clients, figure out pricing for your services, and more.

The second section, The Art of Freelancing, covers what to expect in your life as a freelancer — how to deal with rejections, when to fight for your voice in client work, if and how you should use AI, and the different career paths you could take from here.

And the last section is us vehemently rooting for you!

You can read it from start to finish in one go, or you can scan the table of contents and pick topics you have questions about.

But before beginning, we'd like you to keep in mind that you will not find ready-to-use templates or cookie-cutter answers here. This is because we believe that the work of a writer is to read, think, and come up with their own answers, to use their own words. We would never strip you of that opportunity. We have created this playbook in that spirit.

Consider this a structure to hold your thoughts within and reshape them as often as you need. Page by page, we hope you can piece together a realistic picture of what to expect if you choose this for yourself, of how you can grow as a creative professional and as a writer.

So then, let's get started?



I.

The Business of Freelancing



1. Deciding if freelancing is right for you

There are all kinds of journeys that lead to freelancing — folks who start as freelancers, those who freelance between full-time jobs, and those who switch from full-time to freelance. Our journey has been the last kind.

After 3–4 years of working full-time, Aparajita was between jobs, and Soumya was on a break due to health reasons. Because we had already built some credibility in our earlier roles, freelance projects began to come our way once we activated our network. One thing led to another, and before we knew it, we found ourselves working as full-time freelancers. At that point, freelancing stopped feeling like a temporary phase and became a real career choice, which also meant we experienced its realities firsthand.

People on LinkedIn will have you believe that freelancing is the ultimate dream. **Flexible hours, creative freedom, working from cafes,** and basically doing what you love. But we have no qualms stating that freelancing is not for everyone. Yes, it gives you the freedom to choose the kind of work you do and the hours that suit you. And for some, it can mean having more time for other things in life.



But on the flip side, freelancing also means you're never entirely sure what your next paycheck will look like or when it will arrive. You'll find yourself constantly pitching, networking, and looking for new clients.

So, **before you take the leap, here are a few questions** you should be asking yourself.

- **Do you have something or someone to fall back on?** For some, this might mean having your partner's salary as a fallback. For others, it could mean living with parents, so rent is not a monthly worry. And for many, it could be a financial cushion they have built for themselves over the years. Whatever form it takes, a safety net matters more than you think.
- **Do you have the right attitude for it?** We recently came across the term high agency, and we think it is one of the most important traits you need to succeed as a freelancer, or at anything, really. High agency people are proactive. They spot problems, create opportunities for themselves, and find ways to make things happen. The good news is that high agency isn't an innate personality trait; it's a skill you can build over time through repeated choices. This can look like pitching for work even when no one has asked, saying yes to projects you're not confident about, and sticking with them long enough until you actually get the hang of it. It means sustaining momentum without external deadlines, promotions, or managers pushing you forward.

- **Are you ready to wear multiple hats?** When working independently, you are your own sales, marketing, finance, and operations team. You'll have to hunt for leads, do outreach, pitch yourself, onboard clients, and handle all communications while you deliver the work.
- **Are you comfortable working alone?** Freelancing often means long hours by yourself, without colleagues to chat with or brainstorm alongside. Even as introverts, we miss those casual water-cooler conversations and mid-day gossip sessions. Working solo can feel freeing at first but over time, it can also get lonely. You might start feeling a bit disconnected from your peers, with no real way to compare notes or see how others in your field are doing. And during slow months, that can easily spiral into self-doubt or feeling like you're falling behind. And if you feel you're still not there yet, you needn't worry too much. You can always collaborate with other freelancers — more on this in our section about *Building a freelance support system*.
- **Are you prepared for what freelancing actually looks like in practice?** Freelancing does give you control over your hours, but you might still find yourself working late nights or weekends to meet deadlines, or saying yes to projects you don't love just to keep the cash flow steady. The flexibility is real, but so is the hustle. For instance, we love that we can tell a client, "Sorry, we can't do a call today" for a last-minute request. But the truth is, if we care about the client and have the time, we'll probably still say yes. So while you gain control over your schedule, you'll still end up handing out big chunks of it.

These questions aren't meant to discourage you from freelancing, but simply to help you think through what the reality of it might look like.

Freelancing can be incredibly rewarding for the right kind of person, but it also comes with its fair share of uncertainty and responsibility. It might help to talk to a few freelancers you know, hear about their experiences, and see what parts of the lifestyle resonate with you.

For us, freelancing happened almost by accident and slowly turned into a career. For many of you, it might be a much more conscious decision. Either way, if you decide to give it a shot, the next sections of this playbook will **walk you through some of the practical things** that make freelancing a little easier to navigate.



2. Setting up the basics

*What services do you offer? Do you have an area of expertise?
Could you share your portfolio and rates?*

Welcome to the background score of your life as a freelancer.

Don't worry, you'll get the hang of it all quickly. But to start with, let's break things down.

1. Pitch

Your first step is a simple pitch: What do you do? What makes you good at it? What specific value do you offer a client that cannot be replicated easily? If you're struggling with identifying your core strength and niche, we've covered this in depth in *The Art of Freelancing*.

This pitch will go on top of your resume, your portfolio, in all your professional bios, while filling out applications, and even when you start a conversation with a potential client.

If you have been writing for a while, you've already got that pitch at the back of your mind. If you are new to the field, talk about what you are interested in and why. Keep it short, two to three sentences at most.



Examples:

- Reema Mukherjee: I'm the co-founder of Yours Bossy, a boutique content studio for people who are brilliant at what they do, but need a sharp mind to shape how the world sees them. This business is my response to years of watching great ideas get buried under bad communication. Not just in what audiences see, but in the conversations that happen (or don't) inside ideation rooms.
- Pragati Gupta: Words are powerful, and when used right, they don't just tell stories; they build brands. Hi, I'm Pragati Gupta, a copywriter, content marketer, and LinkedIn creator who helps businesses and professionals turn ideas into content that sells, scales, and sticks.

2. Portfolio

When a potential client asks to see your work, sure, you can send over a list of links. But a portfolio says you're professional and ready to hit the ground running. It also helps you push your work when no one is asking.

Your portfolio can be a website, a Notion page, a slides deck, or heck, even a Google Document. But the harder and more important question is, what should you include and focus on when building one?

Tips for freshers:

- **Maintain a blog or newsletter.** It could be about anything that interests you. Soumya's angsty 3-year-old blog was the pitch that landed her her first job!
- **Offer your services to friends and family.** Don't charge much, do it for the (portfolio) plot.
- **Do copy/content/branding experiments** with the collateral of brands you love. Add them to your portfolio as faux projects. To showcase your versatility, try creating work for different kinds of businesses — a landing page for a D2C brand, an email campaign for a bookstore, or a social media strategy for a startup.

Tips for experienced writers:

- **Pick your best projects.** The ones that felt most rewarding once completed. Talk about the project brief, show your work, and if possible, mention the impact. If you're looking for more creative work, add awards or unique commissions to help clients understand how your work is valued in the larger creative ecosystem.
- **Showcase diversity.** Clients want to know how well you can adapt to their industry and offerings. While you may never have experience in every industry, displaying a few varied projects should do the trick.

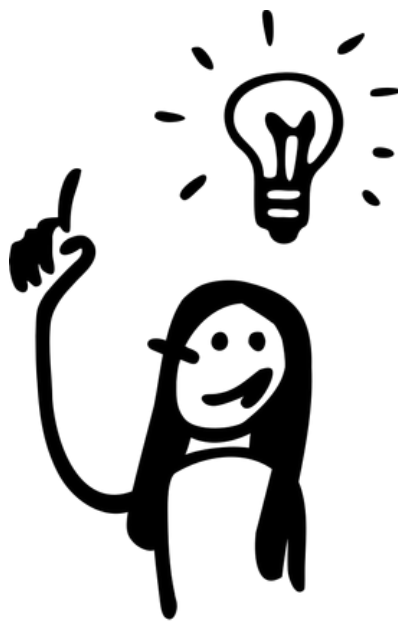
- **Draw attention to your niche.** While showcasing varied projects, highlight your niche (be it skill, subject matter interest, or both). What's the common thread across your work? This makes your services stand out.
- **Use language as a subtle signal.** If you are a technical writer, use direct and plain language that shows you know how to break things down. If you are interested in more creative work, weave a narrative into your showcase. These work as subconscious signals which tell a potential client you know what you're talking about.

Resources:

Hosting options: [Wix](#) | [Squarespace](#) | [Canva](#) | [Framer](#) | [Lovable](#) | [Notion](#)

Portfolios we love: [Kiran Shahid](#) | [Megha Sawhney](#) | [Christina Sterbenz](#) | [Muriel Vega](#) | [Manon Arnaud](#)

[What you need to set up for vibe coding your website](#)
[How to vibe code your website using Claude Code](#)



3. Figuring out how to charge

One experience every freelancer can speak to is the early days stress of not knowing how to figure out the right rates for a project.

We don't enter the market knowing exactly what sort of clients and projects we will come across. Opportunities can be eclectic, with charges varying according to the type of work, country they are based in, timeline of the assignment, and so on. So how do you figure it out?

Pricing and negotiation

Begin with **building a rate card** so you don't have to do the math from scratch each time. List what services you offer, what goes into each, and how much you charge. Do some market research to learn where you stand and do not undersell yourself.

A potential client may ask you for your commercials right away. If you feel confident, go ahead and share your rates. It's also alright to ask for their budget, the scope of the role, and company documents to help you better understand the brand. In this way, you get to take a step back and calibrate before deciding what feels fair.

Many clients are not willing to disclose their budgets, though. If that's the case, use the meeting to understand what they need and tell them about your work. When you do quote your price, a good practice is to **quote 15-20% higher** than your rate and negotiate from there. Also, ensure there's a paper trail; WhatsApp is a big no-no.



How writers usually charge

While a rate card is useful, it also helps to have a general gauge on the ways you can charge. So let's look at the most common methods of charging:

- 1. Per word.** Makes sense for work like blogs with limited research.
- 2. Per hour.** This suits consultancy roles where a good amount of your time goes into ideation/planning/training creative teams/etc.
- 3. A flat fee based on the scope of the project.** This is our favourite way to charge for diverse projects as it takes several factors like time, energy, and value of output into account.
For example, 10 SEO blogs for Rs. 50,000 over 2 months.
- 4. Retainers.** Monthly retainers are the lifeblood of a freelancer because they provide stability. If you have ongoing value to offer, consider pitching for a retainer position. This could look like: 4 blogs + social media plan every month for Rs. 30,000.

For those of us who are new to money talk, this part of the job can feel intimidating. But do it a few times and you'll come to know that it's a fairly ordinary skill that opens a universe of possibilities for you. Who you pitch to, how you think about money, and how far your career goes can all shift once you get comfortable talking numbers.

4. Finding, choosing, and growing the right clients

If you're looking for a foolproof formula, there isn't one. Most of it comes down to timing, conversations, trial and error, and simply showing up consistently. Some clients appear out of nowhere, while others take months of quiet follow-ups. And trust us when we say this, pitching almost always feels awkward at first, no matter how long you've been doing it.

In this section, we walk through what's worked for us — how we find clients, how we pitch, and the green flags we've learned to look for.

Finding clients

A large majority of our clients come through **word of mouth**, primarily from (current and former) colleagues and past clients.

We've also landed work through **friends and family**, so don't hesitate to remind people what you do from time to time. A simple check-in or "know anyone who might need this?" can go a long way.

Responding to open calls on LinkedIn or aggregators (a few of which we mention across the playbook) could work. But these usually get a high volume of applicants and it is harder to cut through the noise.

What is more likely to catch a company's attention is **cold mailing**. Find companies in industries you are interested in, and figure out the right people to reach out to. Personalize your pitch and shoot your shot. Not everyone will respond, but many will.

We have also learnt that even one **face-to-face interaction** at a networking or community event, workshop, or casual meet-up makes you more real to others. People remember you, and when work comes up, they think of you.

And of course, **good work travels**. When you show up consistently and do the job well, recommendations follow.

Choosing the right client

Not every client project needs deep scrutiny. For one-off gigs that pay well, we don't overthink it. But for retainers or longer projects, we slow down and evaluate more carefully. We ask ourselves a few simple questions: *Do we understand the product? Can we contribute meaningfully over time? Do we like how the team works? And do they respect freelancer boundaries?*

Over time, we've learned to pay attention to certain green flags. Clear communication from the start is always a good sign.

Clients who know what they want (or are honest about what they don't). They respect your time, respond on time, and don't disappear mid-conversation. They're open to your inputs and treat you like a collaborator, not just someone executing instructions.



Payment terms are discussed upfront, there's mutual respect, and they value your expertise, trust your process, and don't make you feel like you have to constantly prove your worth. More on red flags and clients to be wary of in the chapter about *Refusing projects and ending client relations*.

Pitching without feeling scared or icky

While we're sharing this gyaan, we'll admit, pitching doesn't come naturally to us either, and that's completely fine. The trick is to think of yourself as a company that sells services. How does this company make money? By signing new clients. And how does it get those clients? By marketing what it does best. So when you're pitching, you're not being pushy; you're simply doing what every business does to grow. And this mindset shift alone takes away a lot of the awkwardness and self-consciousness that comes with pitching.

Still, even with that perspective, pitching often requires a strange amount of confidence. Especially when you're trying something new or stepping outside your comfort zone. But here's the thing, most people aren't good at a job before they have it. Show up, do the basic research, and put your best foot forward, and you'll be surprised how often that alone pays off in the long run. Think of it as a bit of a fake it till you make it situation.



Turning good clients into long-term associations

It's important to find people you genuinely enjoy working with. These are the clients who trust us and let us steer the ship instead of micromanaging every little thing. They like how we work and what we bring to the table, so over time, they've allowed us to contribute more, which naturally means a bigger scope of work and higher fees.

And that kind of trust doesn't just happen. You earn it by showing up consistently and proving that you're dependable. As freelancers, being proactive and reliable goes a long way. We've noticed that clients are often more impressed by this behaviour from freelancers than from full-time employees, maybe because they assume freelancers are less reliable by default. Taking ownership, following through, and not waiting to be chased is how you become their go-to person.

That go-to status sometimes comes with extra effort. For clients who respect our time, boundaries, and pay us fairly, we don't mind going the extra mile, even if that means occasionally working late nights or weekends. Many of these clients have gone on to recommend us for other projects, which is why maintaining good relationships with both current and past clients matters.

Moreover, when you work closely with founders at small startups, you also realise that many of them just need a sounding board; someone to reassure them, talk things through with, and help them feel grounded. And while this might not be part of the official job description, it's one of the reasons most of our clients now come through referrals.

5. Managing payments and delays

Culturally, people don't like talking about money. It's considered rude to ask someone what they earn, and even discussing fees too openly can feel a bit uncomfortable. It's one of those topics that most of us are taught to quietly avoid. But as freelancers, we don't really have that luxury. Money is part of the job, and there's no one else to have that awkward conversation on our behalf.

We've found that being upfront from the very beginning saves a lot of pain later. Have a clear paper trail for payment expectations, timelines, and scope of work. If it's a long project or a retainer, a contract is a must. Most companies will provide it. If not, share your own simple one. Even for smaller projects, make sure you have written communication agreeing to the terms, payment, and payment date of a project.

Have an invoice template ready and send it as soon as the project is completed. Also spell out what happens in case of delays, whether that's a late fee or pausing work until dues are cleared.

When delays do happen, we start with a polite reminder email and follow up if needed. We ask for a new expected payment date and hope, with all our hearts, that it doesn't come to another confrontation.



Luckily, most of our clients have been great with payments, but it always helps to have systems in place rather than relying on luck. And if nothing works out, escalation is sometimes necessary, whether that's a social media callout or legal recourse.

Once in a while, you'll run into a client who genuinely can't pay on time. One of Soumya's long-term clients hit a financial rough patch and payments were delayed by nearly four months. But the CEO kept the team updated throughout, which made it easier to trust the client and stick around. At the end of the day, most payment issues can be avoided with clear communication and a bit of structure. It may feel uncomfortable at first, but setting boundaries around money is part of being a freelancer.

Of course, getting paid is only half the battle. Figuring out what happens after the money lands in your account is another. Unlike full-time employees, freelancers are responsible for managing their own taxes, invoices, and paperwork. While the process can seem intimidating at first, it becomes much easier once you understand the basics.

Start by gathering your invoices, bank statements, and any TDS certificates (Form 16A) sent by clients who've deducted tax. You'll also need your Form 26AS and AIS, which can be downloaded from the Income Tax portal. Next, add up your earnings for the financial year and subtract any work-related expenses, like software subscriptions, internet bills, equipment, or travel. Many freelancers choose to file under Section 44ADA, which lets you declare 50% of your income as profit without maintaining detailed accounts. Finally, file your return online using ITR-4 or ITR-3 and verify it to complete the process.

6. Creating a routine that works for you

There's something highly satisfying about your time being your own, isn't there? You get to decide how much of it you allot to various clients and when you will be available to them.

But as we've been discussing, there can be a downside too. Most of us have grown up, studied, and worked with established routines for large chunks of our days. If you are new to freelancing, there's a chance you may never have planned an entire work week for yourself before.

This realisation usually sneaks up on you a few months in, when you feel overwhelmed by the amount of time on your hands.

It doesn't have to be that way, though. Foresight and a little planning can do wonders when it comes to having a routine in place. So let's look at the two common freelancer scenarios, and how you can anticipate and approach each.



For packed work periods:

Have a general routine for your day. It doesn't have to be minute-by-minute; a loose structure of what your day looks like will be enough. Plan when you usually sit to work, when you take a break for lunch, resume work again and end your time at the desk. You could think of major tasks as tentpoles across your day. You may have 2 or 3 tentpoles in a stretch of 7 or 8 hours. Allow your day to take shape around those.

Ideas to structure busy workdays better:

- Having **a dedicated workspace** has helped Aparajita establish her work routine. Working from her sofa or bed used to blur work and personal time boundaries. But a home office with a dedicated workspace that she has designed to match her vibe means she doesn't dread sitting down to work each morning.
- **Do a check every Monday.** What's been carried over from last week? What new tasks do you have in store? This 10-minute exercise will give you clarity about what is in store for the week, forming a mental rhythm before you even consciously map it out.
- **Maintain clear task visibility.** For project management, Aparajita uses a Google Sheets tracker or a Trello board and Soumya uses a journal and the digital trackers each client prefers.
- **Consider coworking**, especially if you are working from home. Having a body double can help you get a lot more done. Schedule time with friends or fellow freelancers who also work remotely, or use platforms like Focusmate or Flow.

For periods of low external accountability:

If you have a packed schedule, it's easier to prioritize, divide tasks, and get work done. But what about when you don't have enough work? How do you still apply yourself to a day?

A few suggestions:

- When it comes to retainer clients, there will be stretches with a lot of breathing room. Don't beat yourself up over that because you'll have equally busy stretches of time.
- Whatever work you do have (even if it's client-hunting), do it at the beginning of a day and week. That way, you gain momentum.
- Spending too much time cold mailing or fielding rejections can start to feel hopeless. Working without external accountability also means double the internal pressure. So figure out what feels reasonable to ask of yourself and only commit to that much. If you're taking on other creative projects that are long-wound, free, or don't guarantee pay, don't take on more than one or two at a time.
- Expect less from yourself during times when you have less work and less external accountability. Because most of the work you're doing right now is invisible even to you — it's simply waiting.

7. Handling feedback and pushing back when needed

Our #1 tip for handling feedback is simple: learn to separate your work from yourself. We know it sounds terribly clichéd, but it's true — it's rarely personal. This small shift and that little step back will help you see the larger picture without spiralling into self-doubt.

Once you can look at feedback objectively, the next step is figuring out how to deal with it in practice. When should you take it on board, and when should you stand your ground? Over time, we've understood that the answer often depends on two things: the scope of your work and the ownership you have within it.

Scope as a gauge

When it comes to handling feedback, your project scope is your best guide and guardrail. What exactly does your role cover? How many rounds of revision are included?

We've worked with clients who asked for far more revisions than discussed, without a clear reason or change in scope. In those cases, we first try to understand the why. If the requests still feel random or open-ended, we explain that it's difficult to accommodate them within the agreed budget and scope.

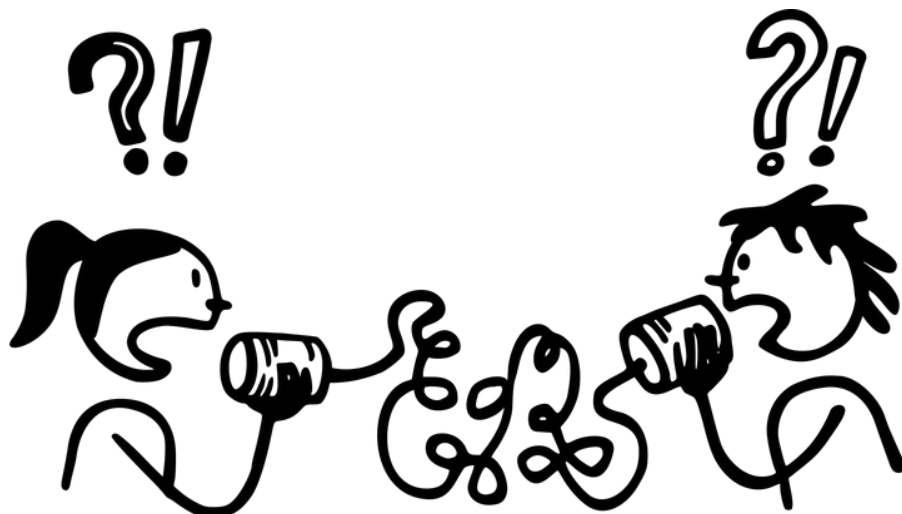
On the other hand, there have been projects where the work genuinely evolved midway — ideas sharpened, goals shifted, or the vision expanded. When we were aligned with the person, the product, or the new direction, we didn't push back much. In those cases, flexibility felt fair because the change was intentional, not arbitrary.

Ownership as a gauge

Another factor to consider, especially with retainer clients, is ownership. What exactly are you responsible for? Are you working with a marketer or strategist to execute their plan, or are you the one driving strategy and results? Your ability (and appetite) to push back depends heavily on that.

At the end of the day, we'd just say that we are humans and not all our decisions will be purely business ones. If we like a client, are more invested in a company, or believe in someone's mission, we may grant them more leeway and take their feedback more seriously. If a client has terrible manners and makes us feel taken for granted, we may want to assert ourselves.

All of that is fair because being able to make those little decisions on a case-by-case basis is what makes being a freelancer different from being a full-time employee.



8. Raising your rates the right way

Raising your rates can feel uncomfortable, especially when you've built friendly, long-term relationships with clients. We've delayed it more times than we should have, worried about sounding greedy or, worse, losing the client altogether.

Over time, we've had to consciously unlearn that fear and remind ourselves that rate increases are a natural outcome of growth. As your skills deepen, your judgement sharpens, and your work begins to need less hand-holding, your pricing should evolve too. The real challenge isn't whether to raise your rates, but knowing when and how to do it without burning bridges.

Raising rates with retainers: When you've been working with a client for a while, just like full-time employees, freelancers can (and should) ask for raises. This could be every six months or once a year. But make sure you up your rates with the level of experience and trust you bring. This is also a good way to collect feedback. Treat it like a regular appraisal, ask what your clients like about working with you, and where there's room for improvement.



Raising rates for scope creep: If you've taken on more work than agreed upon, don't shy away from addressing it. With retainers, scope creep happens easily. Often, one quick task becomes a regular expectation. If it's a one-off or something minor, fine, let it go. But if it's recurring or time-consuming, make a note and raise it in your next review. You can politely say that either it needs to be reassigned or compensated for.

Raising rates by offering complementary services: One of the easiest ways to make more money is to pitch complementary services to existing clients. If you manage website content, suggest starting a blog. If you write blogs, propose a weekly newsletter. If you handle social media, offer to set up performance tracking. Small additions like these can gradually help you build bigger retainers.

Raising your overall rates: Beyond client-specific raises, make sure you're updating your overall rate card from time to time. Say, every year or after every 10 clients. Your rates should reflect your growing expertise and body of work. Growth tends to be faster in the early years, and then it plateaus. That's when you'll need to push for more complex, challenging projects that add depth and perspective to your portfolio, and justify higher rates. For example, you might start out writing blog posts but later take on more complex projects, such as SEO-driven content strategy, long-form reports, or brand narratives that require deeper thinking and research.

9. Refusing projects & ending client relations

One of the hardest things to learn in freelancing is that not every opportunity is worth saying yes to. Over time, you realize it's okay to walk away from work that doesn't align with your rates, your time, or how you want to work.

When Aparajita first started freelancing, she worked with a company that paid fairly well for someone new in the game. But of course, it was too good to be true. The founder was a micromanager and expected a yes (wo)man on the job. So while the pay was good, they weren't easy to work with.

They've reached out a few times since, but she's politely declined. What worked then doesn't work anymore. And often, making that call becomes easier when you start recognizing certain patterns early on.

Let's look at some of the most common ones we recommend watching out for.



- **When they are vague about budgets.** Stay away from clients who dodge the money question or say things like, “We’ll figure it out once we see the work.” That usually means they want to underpay you or haven’t valued the project enough to plan for it. Always clarify budgets up front. It saves time and avoids awkward conversations later.
- **When they micromanage.** You can usually spot them early... The ones who want constant updates, nitpick every line, or rewrite your copy entirely. This often signals a lack of trust, and over time, it slows the work down and drains your energy.
- **When they don’t respect your time.** They expect you to be available beyond agreed hours, frequently reschedule or cancel at the last minute, or are perpetually late with payments and seem unbothered by it.
- **When they want too much upfront.** Long unpaid assignments, lengthy questionnaires, or extensive “tests” before even clarifying the scope or budget. If you’re already working this hard before you’re hired, imagine what it looks like after.
- **When they don't know what they want.** If a client can’t articulate what they’re looking for even after a couple of conversations, you’re already stepping into confusion. It gets worse when they also don’t trust your judgement. That’s the perfect recipe for an endless loop where no one is happy with the feedback or the final output.

Individually, these might seem manageable. But over time, they tend to cost more than they're worth, both in terms of time and energy.

That said, the ability to refuse work often comes from a place of financial stability. During slower months, saying no isn't always realistic, and that's okay too. But when you are in a position to say no, how you choose to handle it makes all the difference.

Here's how we usually go about it.

- **Before ending a relationship.** Ask yourself if there's room to work things out. Maybe you just need a higher rate, more structure, or clearer expectations. If that's possible, have a respectful, honest conversation. If not, and the reason for leaving is more personal (for instance, you're discontinuing a service, feeling burnt out, or taking time off for a passion project), communicate it truthfully, at least to the extent you're comfortable sharing.
- **When things end anyway.** Ending client relationships can be challenging, and sometimes simply out of your control. If a client chooses to make the process messy, there's only so much you can do. But in most cases, the best way to go about it is: separate yourself from the work. A project not working out doesn't mean you failed; it just means the fit wasn't right. They'll find another writer, and you'll find another client.
- **Leave on a good note.** How you leave really matters. You never know where or when your name might come up next. Being remembered as kind, dependable, and professional often does more for you than the project itself. Even work that doesn't turn into a long-term relationship leaves an impression, so make sure it's one that opens more doors than it closes.

II.

The Art of Freelancing



1. Understanding what you offer as a writer

What do you offer as a writer?

We're not talking about the services you can provide. A ton of folks provide the same services, many do it well, and some will even be more skilled than you. But what do you offer that no one else can?

It's simple: *your perspective*.

Now let's get this straight, your perspective won't be a string of buzzwords like 'emotionally intelligent copy with data-driven strategy'. It's something far more nuanced and individual, and is built on curiosity, experimentation, and experience.

To help you understand this better, we'd like to talk about our own journeys.



Aparajita started off as a business reporter at a news wire. But soon, she figured out that she had zero interest in tracking bond yields and decided to aim towards more human-centred storytelling. So she moved to the social media team at another news platform, following which she worked full-time for a digital marketing agency to further that skill.

But the fast-paced environment led to burnout. And while taking some time off, freelance opportunities kept coming her way, which she eventually developed into a career.

Soumya's professional journey began as a community curator at a dating app, where she had the occasional chance to write and create content. A few years in, upon realising what part of the work she enjoyed most, she moved to a complete content role at a nonprofit. This was followed by a health crisis, and the gradual switch to freelancing.

As you can see, we both took separate paths to wind up at a similar place in our careers (in which we are still learning, pivoting, and growing).

But it's not just chance that our paths were so different. It also does not mean that what we each offer today is exactly the same.

For instance, Soumya's first job at the dating app introduced her to the world of personal essay writing, a skill she further built outside her full-time jobs. Today, she helps clients hone their own voice and tell stories with candour and perspective. This specific strength is brought to her blog work, brand building, writing lessons, and even her editing.

For Aparajita, time spent in newsrooms built a strong instinct for clarity, accuracy, and asking the right questions. Later, spending years in social media and digital marketing added a different layer — understanding what catches attention, how people read online, and why good content still needs to travel well. Today, those two things come together in her work: writing or content that's honest and structured, but also practical and audience-aware.

Our perspectives were shaped by a combination of the roles and industries we were exposed to, the people we had conversations with, our natural inclinations and limitations, and even our learnings outside of work. And yours will be too.

To begin, just have the curiosity to try what feels right for you.

Write as much as possible, be it for yourself, your friends, or for small projects. Shift gears and lanes whenever you have to, whenever you can. Treat your first year or two or five as a period of gathering data, trusting that in time, a fuller picture will emerge.

Ultimately, your career will not just be a straight path to one destination or a portfolio of work samples. It will be the story of how your work has evolved, why you chose what you did, and all the interesting things you picked up and discovered along the way.

The great news is that's ultimately what clients really connect with: *a writer who knows exactly what they bring to the table and why.*

Questions to ask yourself while getting started:

1. In the last 5 projects I have done, which did I enjoy the most? What part of it was fun for me? Why?
2. What is something I haven't yet had a chance to try, but feel I will be good at? Why? Is there a way for me to try this out in some small capacity?
3. What is something in this field that others have noted I am talented at? What makes me capable of doing this in a way they find valuable? You can ask others for feedback too.
4. What are some non-writing skills that help me write better? For instance, you may be a highly empathetic person who is able to connect with audiences. You may be a people person and great at gathering stories. Or perhaps you have the heart of a researcher and would be fantastic in a role that requires tons of deep research.

2. Protecting your voice in client work

Show a carefully crafted piece of content that you've written for a company to a friend. Chances are, they will go, "I can hear you saying this to me".

At first, we used to think, "That is so odd! How do our friends hear us talk about what toddler moms should do during the pandemic? Or how a workplace's PoSH Internal Committee should handle a sexual harassment case? These situations aren't part of our lived realities and we would never talk about them!"

But that's the power of your voice.

What does your 'voice' mean as a writer? **It is the *youness* you bring to any piece of work. Your values, the way your brain processes, your sense of humour, how your experiences have shaped you to see and be in this world.** All of this is always present in writing you care about, in some shape and form.



What this does not mean: This does not mean that you should aim to make every brand you write for sound like you. Brands have wide-ranging personalities and specific audiences they each speak to, so you have to tailor your work to match that.

When it comes to working with feedback, we don't believe in arguing too much with a client who may want to tweak our copy. However, if their request doesn't reflect the brand's personality or values, we will point that out and ask for a reason to go ahead and tweak the copy — this act is protecting our voice.

What this means: Protecting your voice with a client means protecting your values and writing using your own systems of logic. If this matters to you, then you probably won't be keen to take on long-term or retainer clients whose products or mission you disagree with, and that's your prerogative. There will be many folks out there doing work that you align with.

Our boundaries: Soumya has worked on a few small projects that she wasn't fully aligned with. While the writing felt a bit icky for her, the money made up for it. On a scale of 1 to 10 in terms of alignment, her goal is 5 and above for short-term clients and 7 and above for retainers.

For Aparajita, there are times when she has insisted on doing things her way with a client. But if they pushed back too much, she struck a compromise so long as it would not go out with her byline.

If protecting your voice as a person is a non-negotiable for you, add values and integrity of mission as strong filters when selecting your clients. This will go a long way in helping you show up and do your best possible work.

3. Dealing with rejections

Rejections never become easy to hold.

If the application mattered to you, if it was a pitch you were attached to, or if multiple rejections land back-to-back, it is going to hurt.

Unfortunately, rejections are a huge part of any creator or writer's life. Be it from potential clients, publications, or agents, they will keep coming. And if you dwell on that feeling of disappointment for too long, you risk it becoming a narrative, a harsh truth you believe about yourself.

For example: *It hurts that I didn't get this → Maybe I was not the right fit for this → Maybe I am not a right fit for any role I want → I probably can't do anything well enough.*

Before this thought process becomes a spiral, you must proactively intervene. Here are a few things we tell ourselves to take rejections in our stride.



1. Rejections mean you are trying. And that's the only way forward.

2. Get comfortable waiting. You can tweak your CV, polish your portfolio, apply for open roles, and keep showing up to network. But if you don't get immediate responses, don't check out and reject yourself. Give it time and keep showing up.

3. Zoom out and experience your worth outside work. Create something, go touch grass, spend time with friends. Put the rejection in perspective against the whole of your life.

4. The world is not out to get you, despite what it may feel like. You are not cursed. And as valid as your pain is, a work rejection is almost never personal.

5. Rejection is a writer's rite of passage. Harry Potter was rejected 12 times. Stephen King's *Carrie*, over 30 times. The original *Chicken Soup for the Soul* was rejected 144 times. Yes, you write for others, but you're a writer too. Your work won't be for everyone.

6. Rejection is not a verdict. When you look at the bigger picture, a "no" is just one moment in a much longer career journey, not an objective assessment of your talent or prophecy of your future.

It may take you an hour or a week to move on from hearing that thanks, but no thanks. However long it takes, know your story is not made of the people and places that don't choose you. Trust that and keep going.

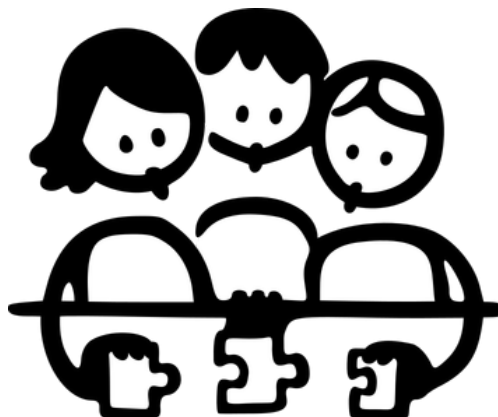
4. Building a freelance Support System

‘Where do I get my next client from?’ was the only question that we both had when we started freelancing.

We quickly began reaching out to our network of ex-colleagues, friends and family, and acquaintances saying that we were available for work. But before long we saw that there was one particular group that would be most helpful — those in similar roles.

They passed along clients they did not have the bandwidth, expertise, or interest to take on. Clients they were moving on from. Or sometimes, just valuable guidance about where to look for work and what to focus on.

Soon, we understood that we too had to pass along the proverbial torch whenever possible. And over time, we saw something bigger: This was not just one writer helping out another in need. **This was an ecosystem, and we had a responsibility to be caring, active members within it.** After all, the work only stays relevant and the conditions only improve when there are enough of us doing this.



Freelancing is a disconnected world though, and most writers operate in their silos. So how do you stay linked to this ecosystem beyond just passing along clients or asking for opportunities?

1. Online networking groups like Draupadi at Work are a fun way to stay in touch with folks who do similar work. Ask and answer questions, offer help beyond just work-related projects.

2. LinkedIn can be a good place to chime in with your thoughts too. Schedule some time each week to drop comments on posts from fellow freelancers. Everyone loves quality engagement and it helps with your own reach too. Bonus points if you keep sending out connection requests with warm notes!

3. If you see opportunities for collaboration, seize them. Better yet, come up with them. For instance, the both of us are loving building this playbook together. It's an excuse to get on call each week, chat about our new outreach efforts, exchange hilarious work stories, commiserate, and champion each other. It gets lonely working by yourself and collaboration is the strongest way to beat it.

4. In-person networking. Attend networking events for writers, creatives, and freelancers. In the words of our friend Reema Mukherjee, who runs a boutique content studio:

"When you meet someone and exchange stories, there's an instant human connection digital spaces can't replicate. Body language matters. It's like dating: FaceTime isn't the same as meeting someone in person. In professional settings too, in-person interactions create natural nudges for deeper conversations that wouldn't happen otherwise."

5. Freelance subcontracting. In this scenario, the primary freelancer takes a cut for bringing in a client and managing the relationship, and the subcontractor gets paid for the work done without having to handle front-end heavy lifting.

On the work front, this setup offers a major advantage for freelancers just starting out as they don't have to worry about pitching, negotiating, or figuring out scope. On the creative front, you gain someone to bounce ideas off of and talk things through with.

We used to think of a professional ecosystem in terms of pure old school networking, and this stressed us out. But once we started to imagine it as a community, we realized that support and nourishment would be part of the package. Today, we can't imagine a better path for expansion and meaningful growth.



5. Working with AI

We want to start by addressing the elephant in the room.

Should you be using AI?

Yes, 100%.

Not just because clients ask for it, but also because it's a tool that'll make your life much, much easier.

In fact, not incorporating AI in your workflow could also be perceived as a red flag by a potential client. Here's what Nisha Ravi, a senior digital marketing professional, has to say about it:

"I actively avoid hiring people who steer clear of AI. One needs to keep up with the times and learning to prompt well and use AI to make you work smarter and faster is crucial."

Having said that, yes, we know there are ethical and environmental concerns worth discussing, but those are larger conversations outside the scope of this playbook. For the purpose of this playbook, we will focus more on how we, as writers and creatives, can use AI to work smarter and faster, without losing our voice or our critical thinking.



Break the pattern. Tools like ChatGPT are excellent at recognising patterns. They can untangle muddled thoughts, fill gaps, and complete a sentence. But writing doesn't always move in a straight line.

Our brightest moments of clarity and creativity often come from breaking patterns, not continuing them. That instinct to interrupt, question, and reshape a thought still belongs to humans. And when those moments arrive, it's writing, not prompt generation, that helps you capture them.

Which is why AI works best at the edges, not the centre of your process. Let it help you get started, move faster, or see possibilities, but don't hand it the wheel. The core decisions about what to say, how to say it, and why it matters still need to come from you.

Develop taste and judgement. AI can generate five variations of a paragraph in seconds. Your job is to discern which one is bland, which one is on point, and which one lacks context. This is where you, as a writer, can provide value.

An HBR piece we read recently echoes this sentiment, noting that the edge is no longer just in output but in taste and judgement. And this comes from honing craft. From having written yourself. From having your work edited. From having sat through writing blocks as the deadline draws near.

Edit heavily. Then edit again. AI drafts are starting points, not finished work. What it gives you is structured. Fluent. Often “good enough”. But “good enough” is rarely great writing.

Your job as a good writer is to cut what feels generic. To replace vague phrasing. To include lived context and cultural nuance. To edit, delete, and rewrite until the writing feels like yours. If it doesn’t, the job isn’t done.

Always be the final pair of eyes. More than once, we’ve had AI hallucinate and confidently make up statistics and data points out of thin air, and you don’t want to be caught in a position where you can’t explain where a number came from.

In fact, a simple “Are you sure?” from your end can get tools like ChatGPT to completely change their stance.



The future of writing

Language is how we have always communicated ideas.
Ideas which build and shape businesses, economies, and our lives.

While everyone uses language for basic communication, only some of us were trained to wield its full power. Writing is a type of sorcery after all, using sounds and squiggles to make vivid images, evoke feelings, drive contemplation and action.

Of course it is hard to watch machines do it now. If you are a purist, it's natural to feel that AI can only reanimate, bring to life the soulless undead. But even if you are a realist, there is surely some grief and disillusionment to feel here. We get that.

And we are not here to tell you where AI will be in ten years or to give you a list of appropriate places to use it. Instead, we will say what we know for sure: **neither writing nor language is the same phenomenon it once was.**

And to continue being here, we have to rebuild our relationship with this craft as what it is becoming today. Here's how we do that.

We stop just asking, 'Can AI do what I do?'.

Instead we ask: What do I get from writing on my own and what do I lose? What do I lose from not writing on my own? What does this craft, as it is today, mean to me? Who does that make me?

Hint: You only discover the answers if you keep writing.

6. Levelling up your Skillset & changing lanes when needed

Consider this: If you work for long at a company, you move from Intern to Content Writer to Senior Writer to Content Head. While you will have to spend many years in one place, the growth is already structured for you, all you have to do is follow the path.

It's a little different as a freelancer.

To some extent, growth is inevitable, particularly in your first few years. That said, freelancing is not necessarily structured for vertical growth. Beyond a point, you can simply take on more clients without it challenging you or offering any learning.

But why struggle when you can cruise, right? Why not continue at the same level? It's tricky.

Experience has taught us that this stagnation of energy will drop your own interest in what you do. In time, it impacts how well you are able to show up for your work, or if you can show up at all.

Besides, be it the advent of AI or market shifts, something is always moving the larger axis you operate on. So every now and then, you have to find opportunities to level up in both knowledge and skill.



Easy ways to upskill

1. Take a course. You don't need a new master's degree to understand the basics of generating leads via Instagram. Sign up for an online certification course. Attend webinars or in-person workshops or seminars.

2. Learn on the job. If you are working with retainer clients, learn under senior team members. Learn from handovers and existing brand kits. Learn by offering to experiment with something new for the client. The key is to consciously extend yourself whenever possible.

3. Just be curious. Most simple questions or doubts are one Google search away. The resources are endless if you want to learn something — watch YouTube videos, listen to podcasts, read books and blogs, or heck, ask AI to teach it to you!

Upskilling into a new domain

Not everyone writing content will want to commit to this as a career. If you are someone who is feeling the itch to switch, we've put together a list of plausible career transitions to look at.

1. Branding and creative strategy: Often goes hand in hand with writing, especially copywriting, so you're halfway there already!

*Resources: [The Brand Lab by Bo](#)
[Brand Strategy Guide by Ebaq Design](#)*

2. Performance Marketing: Again, almost all content writers have some level of marketing stitched into their roles. But if you have a head for numbers, this is a lucrative stream to explore further.

3. Social media management: If you love staying on top of trends, enjoy spending time understanding the changing online landscape, and have the knack to reach out and connect with people on the internet, this might be an excellent writing-adjacent role for you.

Resource: [Strong Brand Social](#)

4. Work in publishing: Almost all writers dream of writing their own books someday (including both of us!). There's no better place to further that ambition than by working in publishing. Start off as a junior editor, an author manager, or pitch in hours to bring your favourite local bookstore to the digital world.

Resource: [Bound Publishing Course](#)

5. Community building: There's an unprecedented boom in both online and offline communities at the moment. Practically every other company has an offshoot where they are trying to be in a larger conversation with their customers. If you're the kind of writer who enjoys bringing people together and facilitating conversations, this could be the next stop for you.

Resource: [Community Playbook by Sheena and Reyana](#)

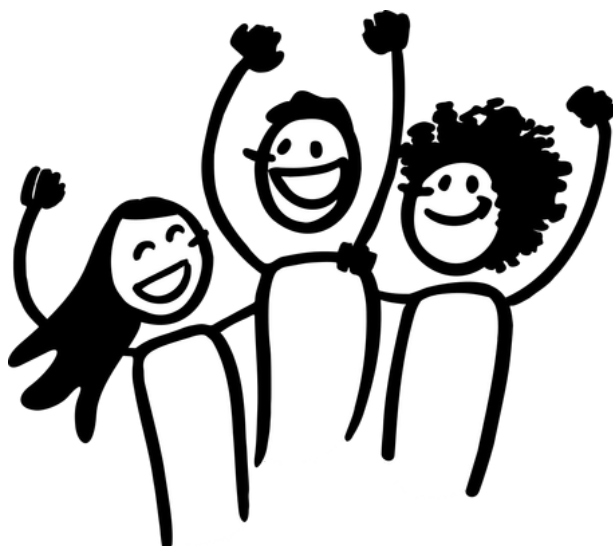


6. Public Relations: Writing and PR are again two sets of skills that are close cousins. Both involve being good at communication and knowing how to speak to a specific audience. Sounds like you?

7. Journalism: Most folks, like the both of us, move from journalism to content. But a switch in the opposite direction is not unheard of. More common, though, are content writers who also pitch to magazines and publications on the side. Every writer knows the value of a reputable byline and perhaps none of us will ever stop chasing that entirely.

Resource for Indian writers: [It's All Write by Joanna Lobo](#).

8. Teaching: If you have the right degrees, teaching English or Creative Writing at an institution is an option. But if you've got good experience, you can always just teach writing workshops. To build a more stable revenue stream, consider partnering with a reputed institute or organization and designing a short course for them.



III. Things We Wish We Knew



1. Hold on to everyday wins.

Freelancing can feel unstable and even chaotic at times, but it also gives you space to shape life on your own terms. And more often than not, the things that ground you are simple: a free weekday afternoon, work that actually feels like you, or the option to close your laptop when you've had enough.

2. Keep time aside to make things for yourself.

You are a creator. If you keep making for others without making for yourself, you'll go nuts. As Mary Oliver said: The most regretful people on earth are those who felt the call to creative work, who felt their own creative power restive and uprising, and gave to it neither power nor time.

3. You never know what will help your career pick up.

Sometimes it's networking on LinkedIn and other times, it's a fantastic personal blog. It could be that moonshot job application you sent or a playbook you write about freelance writing. Point is, learning, introspection, creation, genuine conversations, and reaches of faith are all legitimate ways to keep trying.

4. Writing is not easy work, even for writers.

Come to terms with that quickly so you don't beat yourself up too much. It gets easier, then your standards rise and it gets harder, then it gets easier again, and on and on. Embrace the process.



5. You may burn out.

And that's alright. Burnout is inevitable in today's work environments. Instead of avoiding it, it is more helpful to have a strategy for when it's closing in or when it hits. Writer and early-stage VC Harnidh Kaur suggests we 'time-bound the pain', an interesting idea.

6. Freelancing can mess with your head.

Some days, you're proud of the work you do, and other days, you wonder if you just got lucky. Add financial uncertainty to the mix, and suddenly you're questioning everything. As seasoned freelancers, we've learned to ride it out (with a little help from our friends). The doubt never fully disappears, but you get better at recognising it for what it is — a passing feeling, not a reflection of your talent or worth.

7. Being a freelance writer won't save you from socializing.

A lot of us are introverts and that's why we are called to writing, more so remote/freelance writing. But (we hold your hand as we say this), there will be times you need to initiate conversations. You may have to meet a potential client, do the occasional team lunch, or get on a video call *with your video on*. You'll survive.

8. You will fall off the wagon.

The marketing yourself wagon. The updating your portfolio wagon. The hunting for new clients wagon. The pushing for growth wagon. This isn't a shameful failure or critical career time you wasted; it happens to everyone. Feel the discomfort for a minute and get going with what needs doing.

9. Try before you decide it's not for you.

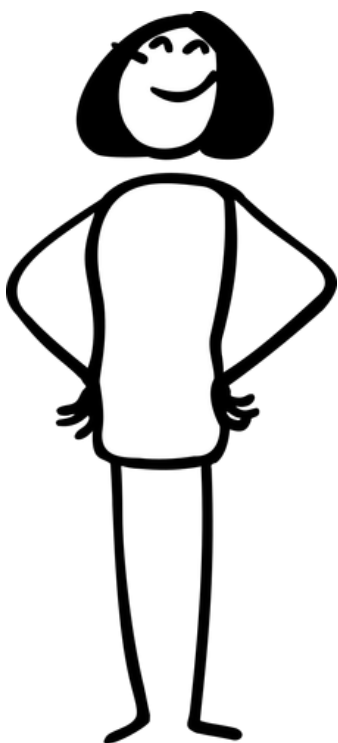
Sometimes it's because the work feels too unfamiliar, or something about it just doesn't feel aligned. And often, it's hard to tell the difference. The only way to know is to try anyway. Step out, take the chance, and if it doesn't land, let it go without guilt.

10. There's no one to cover for you.

When you take a break, the work doesn't stop, it just waits. So, you need to plan ahead, finish what you can, and communicate timelines clearly so nothing slips through the cracks. It's not always simple, but learning how to pause without letting things fall apart is what keeps freelancing steady and sane.

11. Try not to be too self-critical.

Freelancing comes with enough external pressures, and you don't need to add your own voice to that pile. Work will ebb and flow, skills will sharpen over time, and not every project will be perfect. Give yourself some grace, and keep in mind that growth happens much faster when you're not constantly tearing yourself down.



One Last Thing...

If you've made it this far, you're probably looking for certainty.

We understand. We were too.

We wanted someone to tell us how much to charge, where to find clients, how to know when to quit our jobs, how to avoid mistakes, and whether freelancing would work out in the end.

The truth is that no playbook, not even this one, can answer those questions for you.

What it can do is help you start with a little more clarity, a little more confidence, and fewer surprises.

The rest you'll learn the same way every freelancer does: by sending the pitch, taking the call, quoting the rate, making mistakes, and figuring things out as you go.

There is no perfect moment to begin. There is only the moment you decide to take yourself seriously.

We hope this playbook makes that decision a little easier. And if it has, we'd love to hear from you about it.

See you on the other side.

X

Aparajita & Soumya

About the authors

Soumya John is a writer, editor, and content strategist from Bangalore who has spent the past decade helping mission-driven startups find their voice and tell their stories well.

Outside of client work, she is a personal nonfiction writer and zine-maker, currently working on her debut novel. Her writing has appeared in publications including *Feminism in India*, *Homegrown*, *Arré*, *Yahoo*, and *The Mighty*, while her zines have been featured in festivals and exhibits in India and abroad.

Soumya is also developing workshops for creatives, and offers personal writing coaching for people looking to strengthen their practice or work through a project. If any of this sounds like what you need, you can connect with her on [LinkedIn](#), [Substack](#), [Instagram](#), or if spotted by a lakeside in Bangalore.

Aparajita Khandelwal is a writer, content strategist, and brand storyteller. For nearly a decade, she has helped startups, founders, and businesses find their voice, shape their narratives, and tell their stories with clarity and purpose.

A lifelong book lover, she is also the founder of [Paperhearts Marketing Co](#), where she helps indie authors and publishers share their stories with the world. When not working, you'll find her experimenting with healthy recipes, tending to her balcony garden, or reading with her two cats curled up nearby.

If you'd like to work together, exchange ideas, or talk books and brands, connect with her on [LinkedIn](#) or visit her [website](#).

Acknowledgements

We originally planned to build this playbook based solely on experiences we both had, and knowledge we gathered along the way. But we quickly saw that while creating for a community, we needed inputs from the community. So we reached out...

We are grateful to our friends and fellow freelancers who took the time to pitch in with their own learnings and expertise.

Nisha Ravi
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Hiranshi Mistry
Samay Soni
Subha C

And to everyone who has guided us in this writer and freelancer life.
Thank you.

Maybe I Should Freelance?

The A-Z of Building a Sustainable
Freelance Writing Career

**APARAJITA KHANDELWAL
& SOUMYA JOHN**

